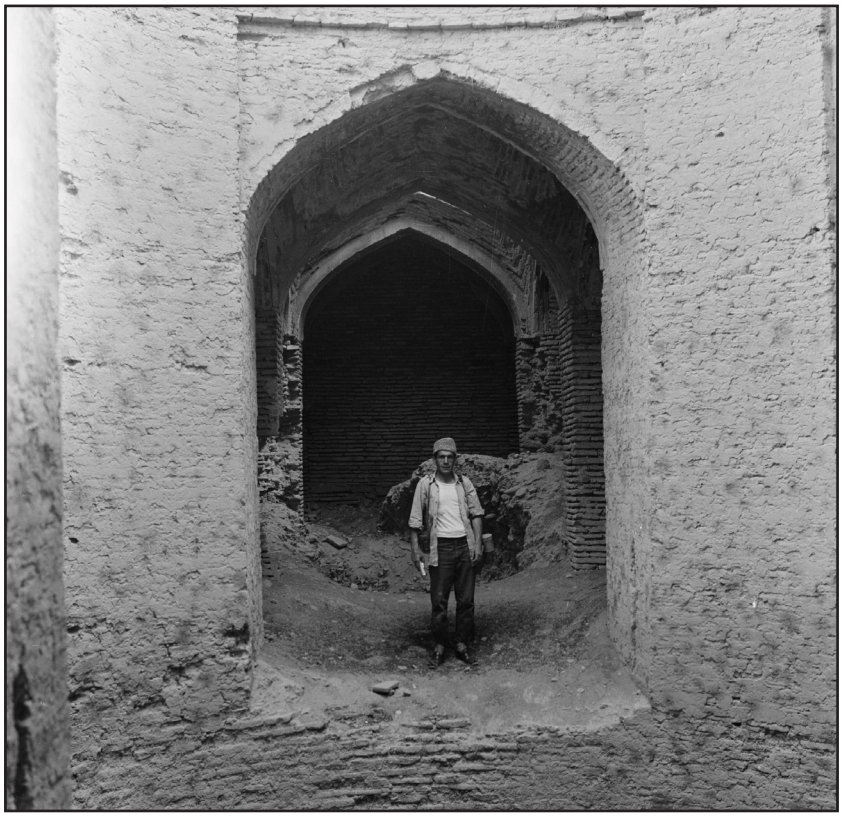


Figure 5.10 *Bust, citadel, ruins, interior, seven-story well: man stands among upper floor arches. © Photograph Josephine Powell* c. *1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

predictably constructed of mud and baked brick, the well's extremely rare if not unique configuration appears to have no precedents in western Eurasia, but its form and function are comparable to the numerous stone stepwells throughout the Indian subcontinent.

The stepwell tradition extended from the seventh through at least the sixteenth centuries throughout the subcontinental region – and evidently also included Muslim patrons of what were essentially "civic" works for community benefit.[32] Numerous stepwells dating to the eleventh–twelfth centuries still survive throughout the north Indian *duab*, and would have surely been encountered during both the Ghaznavids' (*c.*1000–1040 CE) campaigns into northern India, as well as the Shansabanis' own forays as of the late 1170s, and more consistently in the 1190s – either or both of which could have served to transport the general concept from Hindustan to Zamindawar. Given the Bust structure's overall proportions and *structural* affinity with Ghaznavid- and Shansabani-patronized architecture, the well could be tentatively dated to the eleventh–twelfth centuries.[33]